EL NIÑO ACTION BRIEFING · 26 SEPTEMBER 2026 · VERIFIED RUN

# Guernsey, Channel Islands

*El Niño barely reaches Guernsey, and the honest briefing says so. What kills here every winter is cold rooms and flu, quietly, about 14 to 29 deaths a year. This winter tilts toward storms first and cold later. The people nobody's list can see are the ones to reach.*

| IMPACT REGION | EXCESS HEAT DEATHS | WINDOW | DOMINANT HAZARD |
|---|---|---|---|
| The Climate Impact Lab region containing Guernsey (the island is about one-fifth of a region) | No figure published for Europe | Jun 2026 – Feb 2027 (heat only; not this hazard) | Winter cold and flu; early-winter storms and surge; the Bridge at St Sampson |

**16/16 recommendations verified.** 8 corrected (partially confirmed), 0 confirmed outright, 3 unverified, 2 redundant, 3 contraindicated. **The funding target moved from £150k to £100k, exactly one third**, at the threshold where this method flags a change; the ceiling fell from £235k to £175k. One proposed trigger was tested against 52 years of daily weather data and would never have fired. **Premise caveat:** El Niño's signal for the Channel Islands is weak and changes sign through the season; this briefing is built on hazards that arrive every winter, with El Niño shifting the odds. **Method caveat:** the session's web-search budget was exhausted; agents worked by direct fetch plus NOAA's daily station records. Age Concern Guernsey's website, the Civil Contingencies Authority's pages, and the Guernsey Met Office climate pages were unreachable.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE




49.45°N 2.58°W, Guernsey · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** Cold rooms and flu kill quietly here every winter, about 14 to 29 deaths a year; El Niño barely reaches the island, and this winter tilts toward storms first and cold later.
- **First action.** Parish Constables and Douzaines, with Age Concern, name a person to knock on the door of every person over 75 living alone, from the first cold spell through March.
- **The money.** £55k floor, £100k target, £175k ceiling; the scarce resource is a person at the door, not more fuel money.
- **Do not.** Do not brand this "El Niño preparedness," and do not trigger anything on a seasonal forecast: the signal here is weak and flips through the season.


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* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

## WHAT EL NIÑO DOES AND DOES NOT DO HERE

- **This El Niño.** The US Climate Prediction Center gives a more than 90% chance of a very strong event and 75% of a "historic" one for October–December 2026.
- **What the Met Office says about this winter.** El Niño will "increase the chances of wetter, stormier conditions for NW Europe, including the UK, in the coming autumn and early winter" (21 August 2026), which "would also likely be milder than normal." Later in winter there is "an increased chance of Sudden Stratospheric Warming (SSW) events… increasing the potential for cold weather," and El Niño "alone does not determine precise weather patterns" (23 September 2026). **Two phases, both as tilted odds, not a forecast.**
- **What it does not say.** The Met Office's El Niño impact map marks a "cold" impact for the Baltic, not the UK, and notes that very strong events such as 1997–98 and 1982–83 reverse it. The last very strong event, 2015–16, gave the UK its second-warmest winter on the Central England record and Storms Desmond, Eva, and Frank. The cold winter of 2009–10 followed a moderate El Niño of a different type and is the wrong analogue.
- **Who dies in a Guernsey winter.** Population 64,781 at the end of 2023: 11,105 between pension age and 84, and 1,965 aged 85 or over, that group up 5.8% in a year; 605 deaths. Applying England and Wales's winter mortality index gives **about 14 to 29 excess winter deaths a year**. That is our arithmetic, not a Guernsey statistic; none is published, and chance variation at 605 deaths is as large as the effect. Globally, cold accounts for 7.29% of deaths and extreme temperatures only 0.86% (Gasparrini 2015), so most cold deaths happen in ordinary cold weeks, not cold snaps.
- **Who is poorest.** Single pensioners have the lowest household income on the island, a mean of £17,857 a year after housing costs (2022); 23% of households and 19% of people are below 60% of median income after housing costs. The 2023 e-census counts 3,078 one-adult households over pension age.
- **Storms.** They damage property and rarely kill here. None of Guernsey's top ten storms caused a recorded local death. Storm Goretti on 8 January 2026 brought an 85 mph gust, hundreds of trees down, every school shut, and a partial roof collapse at the Mon Plaisir flats that evacuated about 50 residents, with no serious injuries.

## WHAT THIS PLACE SHOULD DO

RANKED

Ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort, with the winter-long cold and infection actions first because they carry nearly all the deaths.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Storm actions follow for the November–January phase the Met Office describes.

## A named person who knocks on the door of every person over 75 living alone, through the parish Constables, from the first cold spell

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · FRONTLINE · PHILANTHROPIST · EMERGENCY MGR

ADAPTATION INVENTORY: TORONTO COLD ALERTS, NEUTRAL (A CAUTION)

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | TRIGGER |
|---|---|---|---|
| Parish Constables and Douzaines with Age Concern; Health and Social Care | Lists by 31 October; contact through March | £35k (coordinator, volunteer costs, 300 heater-and-blanket packs) | 3 days in a row with mean ≤3 °C at Guernsey Airport |

Wilkinson 2004 found no income gradient in winter deaths among people over 75, and concluded that fuel-poverty relief "may need to be supplemented." The States already pays the fuel bill for the poorest; what is missing is contact. Alerts alone do not work: no evaluation shows cold-weather alerts reduce deaths, the UK's Cold Weather Plan was followed by falls in cold mortality only in people under 65, and the Adaptation Inventory’s entry for Toronto’s cold-alert programme found no effect (cardiovascular admissions RR 0.98, 0.91–1.05). The knock is the intervention; the trigger only times it. The UKHSA and Met Office Cold-Health Alerts cover England only, so the trigger is the island’s own temperature record. NICE NG6 names isolated, housebound older people as the highest-risk group.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Frontline's one thing stands: the Constable knows who lives alone in the country parishes, and the employer knows the permit workers. Recruit those two before recruiting volunteers. About 1,700 to 2,000 people over 75 may live alone, an estimate from the census count of 3,078 one-adult pensioner households; 300 packs cover about one in six of them. Check whether the Civil Contingencies Authority or Health and Social Care already holds a vulnerable-persons register before building a parallel one.

## Close the two vaccination gaps: home visits for housebound people over 65, and care workers, who are not on the free list*

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST · SKEPTIC · ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Health and Social Care; GP practices; care employers | Finished by end of November | £20k home visits (500 × £40); £15k care-worker doses if confirmed uncovered | Flu and RSV in the people winter kills |

The States already funds the vaccines: adjuvanted flu for everyone 65 and over, care-home residents, carers, and people with long-term conditions, and a single RSV dose at 75 to 79, matching the UK. **Paying for doses would duplicate funded supply.** The gaps are the GP practice administration fee, getting to people who cannot get out, and care workers, who are not listed as eligible; hospital staff are vaccinated through occupational health. Evidence: influenza fell from 6% to 2.4% in vaccinated older adults (RR 0.42, low certainty), though the trial evidence on deaths rests on four deaths and is uninformative. Uptake in Guernsey is unpublished; the first immunisation report is due in late 2026.

## A cold-snap top-up paid through the existing fuel allowance, on a trigger that actually fires here

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · TRIGGER CORRECTED · ECONOMIST · PHILANTHROPIST · ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | TRIGGER |
|---|---|---|---|
| Committee for Employment & Social Security | Decision by 1 December | Not sized | 3 consecutive days with mean ≤3 °C at Guernsey Airport |

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The fuel allowance of £42.42 a week, October to April, is flat: a cold spell adds nothing. The Economist proposed copying the UK's Cold Weather Payment trigger, seven days at or below 0 °C. **Tested against NOAA's daily record for Guernsey Airport, 1973 to 2025, it would never have fired**: the longest run was four days. Three days at or below 3 °C fired in 24 of 52 winters and 11 of the last 25, including the February 2018 cold snap. It still reaches only claimants responsible for heating.

## For the storm phase, November to January: close the west-coast barriers on the spring-tide calendar plus a south-westerly gale forecast, and inspect the roofs of multi-occupancy and care-home blocks

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · HISTORIAN | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: PRECEDENT, US WINTER WEATHER ADVISORIES (LONGER LEAD HELPS)

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| States coastal team; building control and Housing | Tide dates set by 31 October; roofs by 30 November | Staff time; road-closure cost to weigh | A 1984-style overtopping; a Mon Plaisir collapse at night |

The Perelle barriers and slipway storm boards already exist; today the barriers close only "where a flood warning for the west coast is issued by the Met Office." Closing earlier, on the tide calendar plus a gale forecast, is a real change and closes a main road. On 23 November 1984 a storm on a high spring tide breached the sea walls and left a flood lake up to five feet deep. Goretti's partial roof collapse at Mon Plaisir supports the roof inspections and a check that rest centres have room.

## Put the Bridge at St Sampson on a funded timeline: it has no defences and is not on the coastal repair list

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · NOT BEFORE THIS WINTER | HISTORIAN

ADAPTATION INVENTORY: PRECEDENT, US FLOOD DISCLOSURE (DAMAGE PROBABILITY −33%)

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| States Environment & Infrastructure | Funding decision in 2027 | Unsized; about £20k spent on studies in a decade | Surge flooding of the town built on the 1806 reclamation |

The Braye du Valle was drained in 1806 as a defence measure, and the Bridge sits at its harbour end. As of April 2026 the flood defences are still at site investigation and concept design, with no cost or funding, and the parish's constables are sceptical. The 2025–28 coastal priority list is a repair and repointing programme, almost all on the west coast; the Bridge is not on it. For this winter, the Bridge is where to

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

watch on a surge and a spring tide.

## Confirm how many days of diesel the power station holds against a winter-peak burn

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · PARTLY REDUNDANT | EMERGENCY MGR · SKEPTIC · HISTORIAN · ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Guernsey Electricity with the Civil Contingencies Authority | 31 October | Staff time; fuel top-up if short | Rationing if the cable fails in a long cold spell |

Over 90% of the island's power comes over one 60 MW cable to Jersey and France; peak demand reached 94.2 MW in January 2024. The cable failed in 2018 and was replaced in 2019 for £30m. But the power station is required to meet peak demand without its two largest engines, and it carried the island through the 2018–19 outage. **The cable is a cost risk more than a blackout risk.** A full loss-of-cable drill is largely redundant; the one number worth confirming, fuel days on hand, is not published. The larger second cable once planned to Jersey was suspended; a 100 MW cable to France is now the plan, status unconfirmed.

## Clear hospital, harbour, airport, and school routes of weakened trees by 15 November, thinning rather than felling

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| States Infrastructure; tree contractors | 15 November | Tens of thousands of pounds (estimate) | Blocked routes and island-wide school closures |

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Justified on Goretti's hundreds of fallen trees and closed roads. The claim that felling trees after Storm Ciarán exposed others to Goretti could not be found in any source and has been removed.

## Phone older residents of Alderney and Sark in November to confirm 7 to 10 days of prescriptions and food *

UNVERIFIED | FRONTLINE · EMERGENCY MGR | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Volunteers; island authorities; St John Guernsey | November | Volunteer time; kits £20k (ceiling only) | Running short when boats and flights stop |

Alderney has 2,167 people; air evacuation runs only 7 am to 7 pm, and in bad weather patients go by RNLI lifeboat. Sark has about 562 people, no airport, no cars, a 55-minute ferry, and one resident doctor. **Sark is excluded from the Income Support fuel allowance**, whose residency covers Guernsey, Alderney, Herm, and Jethou. No existing scheme was found either way. St John Guernsey now does first aid and training; the ambulance service is a separate organisation.

## Agree days-of-stock triggers for fuel, medicines, and food, tied to cancelled freight sailings

UNVERIFIED | EMERGENCY MGR | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Harbour, Health and Social Care, main importers | 31 October | Meetings | Shortages when the sea links close |

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Feasible and cheap. Whether the Civil Contingencies Authority already holds such triggers could not be checked; ask before building them.

## A one-page storm and cold card relayed by employers and landlords to staff WhatsApp groups, in the workers' own languages

UNVERIFIED | FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Hotels, growers, care agencies; Citizens Advice (WhatsApp line) | 1 November | Volunteer time | Permit workers missing warnings and help |

Short-term permit holders run up to 12 months at a time, cannot bring dependants, and many rent rooms in houses where the householder is present, which keeps them off every address list and likely out of the fuel allowance, which requires responsibility for heating. Whether they can claim Income Support at all could not be confirmed. The languages proposed (Portuguese, Latvian, Polish, Tagalog) match local knowledge but no published figure; check with the Population Management Office. Citizens Advice covers all four islands, sees 5,600+ clients a year, and has a WhatsApp line.

## After this winter: an insulation floor in the rental housing standard, and insulation for pensioner homes

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · POST-PEAK | ECONOMIST · PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST

ADAPTATION INVENTORY: PRECEDENT, GERMANY WEATHERIZATION (FEWER ELDERLY CIRCULATORY ADMISSIONS)

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| States; landlords via the register | 2027 | Landlords; draught-proofing £25k (ceiling only) | The chronic cold that drives most winter deaths |

The minimum housing standards in force since July 2025 require "adequate heating that is adjustable by occupants" but set no insulation or energy-efficiency floor. The evidence is solid for health, less so for deaths: a New Zealand trial found insulation halved the odds of fair or poor health (OR 0.50) and cut wheeze, with a non-significant fall in respiratory admissions. Germany's weatherization programme reduced elderly admissions. Installs by 30 November are unlikely.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

**R** = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal.

| Action | Parish Constables & Douzaines | Age Concern | Guernsey Community Foundation | Health & Social Care, GPs | Employment & Social Security | Environment & Infrastructure | Building control & Housing | Guernsey Electricity | Civil Contingencies Authority | Alderney & Sark authorities | St John & volunteers | Harbour & main importers | Employers & landlords | Citizens Advice |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. Named door-knock for over-75s living alone | **A/R** | **R** | **C** | **C** | | | | | **C** | | | | | |
| 2. Vaccinate housebound people and care workers | | | | **A/R** | | | | | | | | | **R** | |
| 3. Cold-snap top-up through the fuel allowance | | | | | **A/R** | | | | | | | | | |
| 4. Earlier barrier closures; roof inspections | | | | | | **A/R** | **R** | | | | | | | |
| 5. Funded timeline for the Bridge defences | **C** | | | | | **A/R** | | | | | | | | |
| 6. Confirm the power station's diesel days | | | | | | | | **A/R** | **C** | | | | | |
| 7. Clear key routes of weakened trees | | | | | | **A/R** | | | | | | | | |
| 8. Phone older Alderney and Sark residents | | | | | | | | | | **A** | **R** | | | |
| 9. Days-of-stock triggers tied to freight sailings | | | | **R** | | | | | **C** | | | **A/R** | | |
| 10. Storm and cold card for permit workers | | | | | | | | | | | | | **A/R** | **R** |
| 11. Insulation floor for rentals and pensioner homes | | | | | | | **A** | | | | | | **R** | |

What the chart shows. **Row 1 carries most of the deaths, and it rests on parish Constables and a charity.** Its £35k depends on a Community Foundation grant, and whether Age Concern runs befriending could not be confirmed. **Environment & Infrastructure is accountable for three rows, all in the storm phase.** Storms rarely kill here, so the busiest public owner sits on the actions with the fewest deaths. **Row 10 has no public owner.** It relies on hotels, growers, care agencies, landlords, and Citizens Advice to reach permit workers who are on no address list. Row 11 names only "the States", so its A sits with building control and Housing as the body the text most implies. **Sark falls through two rows.** It is excluded from the fuel allowance that row 3 pays through, and row 8, its only cover, is volunteer-run and unverified.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The Philanthropist lens, reconciled and verified. The States already pays the fuel bill for Income Support households all winter; more fuel money there buys the least. The scarce resource is a person at the door.

| FLOOR | TARGET | CEILING | LARGEST UNCERTAINTY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **£55k** | **£100k** | **£175k** | **How cash reaches people just above the Income Support line, permit workers, and Sark** |

Arithmetic. Floor: welfare contact £35k + home-visit vaccination for 500 housebound people × £40 = £20k, total £55k. Target: floor + care-worker doses £15k (only if Health and Social Care confirms they are uncovered) + a pilot of 200 cold-snap top-ups × £150 = £30k, total £100k. Ceiling: target + top-ups back to 400 households (+£30k) + Alderney and Sark outage kits £20k + draught-proofing £25k, total £175k. The lens proposed £150k; the target fell by exactly one third, because paying for vaccine doses duplicates States supply and the top-up channel does not yet exist. Above about £175k, money outruns delivery before January.

| RECIPIENT | USE | AMOUNT | MECHANISM | BASIS | VERDICT |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Age Concern Guernsey with parish Constables, via the Guernsey Community Foundation | Action 1: contact for people over 75 alone; 300 heater-and-blanket packs | £35k | Foundation grant (minimum £5,000; speak to the Foundation first) | NICE NG6 highest-risk group; Wilkinson 2004. Age Concern exists; whether it runs befriending could not be confirmed. The Foundation has given more than £3m to over 100 charities, not the £7m a lens quoted, about £1.3m a year. | Keep |
| Health and Social Care; GP practices | Action 2: home-visit vaccination for 500 housebound people | £20k | Direct grant for the administration and visit cost | Vaccine supply is already States-funded; the gap is getting it to people who cannot get out. | Repriced |
| Care employers | Action 2: flu vaccination for 1,000 care workers | £15k | Direct grant | Care staff are not on the free list; hold until Health and Social Care confirms no employer scheme. | Conditional |

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

| RECIPIENT | USE | AMOUNT | MECHANISM | BASIS | VERDICT |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| To be identified; Citizens Advice runs no disbursement fund | Action 3: cold-snap top-ups for 200 households above the line | £30k pilot | Cash or fuel credit, not electricity credit only | Electricity credits miss oil-heated homes and room renters whose bills are in the rent. No hardship tariff or fund exists at Guernsey Electricity. | Halved, redesign |
| Island authorities in Alderney and Sark | Outage and supply kits | £20k | Pre-positioned stock | Storms rarely kill here; ceiling only. | Ceiling only |
| — | Draught-proofing, 100 homes | £25k | — | NG6 supports it; not deliverable by 30 November. | Ceiling only |

The funder's one thing survives: fund people and contact, not kilowatt-hours. Tie every grant to a 30 November spending milestone with unspent money returned. And judge it by vaccinations given and doors knocked, not by this winter's death count: at about 605 deaths a year, the flu strain will swing the total more than anything a grant does, and any El Niño effect will be impossible to see.

DO NOT DO THIS — CONTRAINDICATED

### Do not brand this "El Niño preparedness," and do not trigger anything on a seasonal forecast

CONTRAINDICATED SKEPTIC; CONFIRMED ON MET OFFICE STATEMENTS

The signal for this island is weak and flips through the season: milder and stormier early, a risk of cold later, and the Met Office itself says it is too early to say. A campaign sold as El Niño preparedness is discredited the day the forecast busts, and it hides the fact that the actions above pay off in every winter.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

**Instead:** all-hazard winter messaging tied to Met Office warnings and observed temperatures.

### Do not copy the UK's seven-days-at-freezing Cold Weather Payment trigger

CONTRAINDICATED VERIFICATION; 52 YEARS OF STATION DATA

It never fired at Guernsey Airport from 1973 to 2025; the longest run at or below 0 °C was four days. A scheme on that trigger would look like protection and pay nothing.

**Instead:** three consecutive days with mean at or below 3 °C, which fired in 11 of the last 25 winters.

### Do not rely on cold-weather alerts alone

CONTRAINDICATED PUBLIC HEALTH · VERIFICATION

No evaluation found shows cold alerts reduce deaths. After England's Cold Weather Plan, cold mortality fell only in people under 65; Toronto’s cold-alert programme found no effect on cardiovascular admissions. Most cold deaths happen in ordinary cold weeks, not the snaps that alerts are built for.

**Instead:** use observed temperature (three days at mean ≤3 °C at Guernsey Airport) to time a knock on the door. UKHSA Cold-Health Alerts cover England only and are not issued for Guernsey.

DROPPED AS REDUNDANT ALREADY IN PLACE

- **Paying for flu and RSV vaccine doses.** The States already funds flu for 65 and over and RSV at 75 to 79.
- **A full loss-of-cable drill and more backup generation.** The power station must already meet peak demand without its two largest engines and did so through the 2018–19 outage; only the fuel-days check is kept.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

| DATE | EVENT | TOLL | WHAT CHANGED AFTER |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1806 | Braye du Valle drained as a defence measure | — | The Bridge at St Sampson built on reclaimed tidal land |
| 15 Dec 1979 | Guernsey's strongest recorded storm, 96 mph | — | — |
| 23 Nov 1984 | Storm on a high spring tide breaches sea walls | Flood lake up to 5 ft deep | — |
| 12 Jan 1987 | Coldest daily mean in NOAA's record, −6.3 °C | — | — |
| 15–16 Oct 1987 | Great Storm: 93 mph airport, 110 mph signal station | 2,000+ trees; an aircraft flipped; no Guernsey casualties | — |
| 25 Jan 1990 | Burns' Day storm, 89 mph | ~40 roofs; hospital theatre closed; one death in Jersey | — |
| 2015–16 | Very strong El Niño; UK second-warmest winter; Desmond, Eva, Frank | — | The analogue for this winter's first phase |
| 27 Feb – 1 Mar 2018 | "Beast from the East": three days of sub-zero mean | — | — |
| 2018–19 | Power cable fails after two faults; island runs on its own station | No blackout recorded | Cable replaced 2019 for £30m |
| 1–2 Nov 2023 | Storm Ciarán, 78 mph; tornado in Jersey | 3 injured in Jersey; no Channel Islands deaths | Jersey closed schools and told people to stay in |
| Jan 2024 | Record electricity peak, 94.2 MW, against a 60 MW cable | — | — |

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

| DATE | EVENT | TOLL | WHAT CHANGED AFTER |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 Jul 2025 | Minimum housing standards: heating required, no insulation floor | — | — |
| 8–9 Jan 2026 | Storm Goretti, 85 mph; Mon Plaisir roof collapse | ~50 evacuated; no serious injuries; all schools shut | — |
| Apr 2026 | Bridge flood defences still at concept design, unfunded | — | Not on the 2025–28 repair list |

The recurrence nobody has noticed, from the Historian and confirmed by the coastal records: the island's lowest town floods on surge and spring tide whatever the Pacific is doing, and it is the one stretch of coast with no defence and no place on the repair list.

## WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREE

UNRESOLVED

- **Drop the El Niño frame** versus **the weak link is no reason to relax**. Resolved by the Met Office's own statements: El Niño is a fair hook for timing, milder and stormier early and colder later, but every action here should stand on its own in any winter.
- **Fuel money** versus **contact**. The Economist wants a cold-snap payment; the Public Health lens and the Philanthropist say money alone does not warm the over-75s living alone. Both kept: the payment through the existing channel on a corrected trigger, the contact funded first.
- **Cable as the single point of failure** versus **the station covers it**. Three lenses flagged the cable; verification found the station carries peak demand without its two largest engines. The open question is how long the fuel lasts.

## WHAT NOBODY COVERED

BLIND SPOT

No lens looked at care homes as a setting, where the Irma-style failure is a heating fault rather than a power cut. No lens asked about people heating with oil when the tanker cannot land, or with bottled gas indoors. No lens counted how many permit workers there are or which languages they speak; no published figure exists. And nobody could reach the Civil Contingencies Authority's plans, so the first call for anyone acting on this briefing is to ask which of these actions already exist in some form.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Each briefing starts from a single, precise place, such as a village, a ward, or a district, because that is the scale at which useful actions differ. We first work out what can honestly be measured there. That usually means the Climate Impact Lab's published figures where they exist, the local rainfall record, census data, and the history of what has actually gone wrong in that place. Where no reliable number exists, we say so plainly rather than stretch a regional figure to fit.

We then put the same question to seven expert perspectives, each run as a separate AI research agent working from real sources. Each one asks what people here can do before the peak to keep each other alive.

- **The Emergency Manager** looks at what failed operationally in past events.
- **The Public Health Scientist** looks at who is most at risk and which interventions have measured effects.
- **The Frontline Responder** looks at how the community actually works and who people trust.
- **The Skeptic** looks for advice that has backfired in comparable places.
- **The Economist** asks who pays, who carries the risk uninsured, and whether any money is pre-arranged to arrive on a trigger.
- **The Historian** looks for the pattern that keeps repeating.
- **The Philanthropist** asks where a grant would do the most good, and how much money the place could realistically absorb before the peak.

The seven briefs are then reconciled. Agreement between lenses counts for less than it appears to, because they often draw on the same famous studies. Where one lens recommends something another calls harmful, both sides are recorded rather than quietly resolved. Every surviving action needs an owner, a date, a cost, and a named payer, or it is marked unfunded. The funding recommendation becomes a bounded range: a floor, a target, and a ceiling, each with its arithmetic shown. Finally, a separate set of agents checks every recommendation against primary sources. They test whether the evidence is real, whether it came from somewhere like this place, and whether the action can be done here in time. Anything found to be harmful is kept in the report under its own heading, because advice that would cost lives is the most important thing a reader can be warned about. The result is a strong, source-checked hypothesis from a simulated panel, not a consensus of the field, and each briefing says so.

**This run.** The session's web-search budget was exhausted, so all thirteen agents worked by direct fetch, supplemented by NOAA's daily station record for Guernsey Airport, which let a proposed trigger be tested against 52 winters. The unverified count reflects pages that were blocked, not claims that were refuted. Six verifiers checked sixteen recommendations; the verdict tags carry the result.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The El Niño projection covers *heat only* and publishes nothing for Europe. The Adaptation Inventory was consulted through its data feed (96 entries, 30 countries): it holds no UK, Channel Islands, or French entry. Its European and cold-weather entries are cited where they apply, including the Toronto cold-alert programme that found no effect.

## HOW THIS BRIEFING WAS PRODUCED

METHODOLOGY

- **Scope.** The location was taken as given: Guernsey, Channel Islands. Climate Impact Lab impact region, as the report records it: The Climate Impact Lab region containing Guernsey (the island is about one-fifth of a region). Mortality figures exist only at that scale (impact regions average roughly 300,000 people); sub-city detail is used for hazard exposure and action design, not for death counts.
- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February 2027. It covers heat only. It is never added to the Impact Map's long-run projections or quoted from the map's GDP-denominated mortality. Where heat is not the dominant hazard, the historical record carries the hazard instead of a borrowed number.
- **Expert panel.** Seven simulated expert lenses (emergency manager, public health scientist, frontline responder, skeptic, economist, historian, and philanthropist) each researched this place independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief.
- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias (whether the evidence behind an agreed action came from a setting like this one) before it counted in an action's favour. Contradictions were kept, not resolved by dropping a side. Actions were ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak, each was given a named payer and trigger or marked unfunded, and the funding placements were reconciled against the ranked list.
- **Verification.** Separate verifier agents checked every recommendation on three tests: evidence (the primary source and its effect size), transferability (whether that evidence came from somewhere like here), and feasibility (whether it can be done here before the peak). Financial actions were also checked for availability in this jurisdiction, a named payer, a trigger threshold, and whether they already exist. The funding envelope was checked for real recipients, published unit costs, and duplication, then re-summed.
- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.
- **Adaptation Inventory.** Consulted; the closest documented precedent for each action, or its absence, is shown in that action's tags.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (vaccine eligibility, and emergency supplies of prescriptions and food) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.
- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total, and no local figure is invented; where data is thin, the report says so and shows the containing geography's number with its arithmetic. Every source is listed below with its verification status.
- **Limits.** The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from web-available sources, not human experts, and no one in this place was interviewed. Gaps specific to this run are recorded in the verification banner and in each action's tags. *Corrected 10 October 2026:* the Met Office lines are now quoted from the verified 21 August and 23 September 2026 posts; an earlier version quoted wording (“simply too early to determine…”) that could not be found. The cold-alert study is now named as Toronto’s city programme rather than a Canadian national one. The door-knock trigger no longer cites a Met Office cold-health alert: UKHSA Cold-Health Alerts cover England only (UKHSA), and no Guernsey equivalent was found, so the Guernsey Airport temperature trigger is the only one. No recommendation changed.

References (verification status in brackets) · CPC ENSO discussion cpc.ncep.noaa.gov · Met Office, record-breaking El Niño metoffice.gov.uk · Met Office, hot summer and cold winter metoffice.gov.uk · Met Office ENSO impacts metoffice.gov.uk [confirmed; "cold" is the Baltic] · 2014–16 El Niño wikipedia · Winter 2009–10 wikipedia · Ineson and Scaife 2009 doi.org [abstract not reachable] · Population bulletin 2023 gov.gg · Household income report gov.gg · 2023 e-census gov.gg · ONS excess winter mortality ons.gov.uk [confirmed; our arithmetic] · Gasparrini 2015 thelancet.com · Demicheli 2018 Cochrane europepmc.org · Howden-Chapman 2007 europepmc.org · Wilkinson 2004 PMC517639 · NICE NG6 nice.org.uk [confirmed] · Winter wellbeing and vaccination gov.gg · immunisation programme gov.gg · RSV leaflet gov.gg [confirmed] · Income Support and fuel allowance gov.gg · housing standards gov.gg · employment permits gov.gg · UK Cold Weather Payment gov.uk · NOAA daily summaries, Guernsey Airport ncei.noaa.gov · Flood Re eligibility floodre.co.uk [confirmed] · Guernsey Electricity supply electricity.gg · prices electricity.gg · customer support electricity.gg · Channel Islands grid wikipedia [confirmed] · Guernsey's top ten storms guernseypress.com · Storm Ciarán wikipedia · Jersey tornado wikipedia · Storm Goretti wikipedia [confirmed with corrections] · St Sampson wikipedia · Bridge flood defences guernseypress.com · coastal management gov.gg · priority list gov.gg · storm barriers gov.gg · climate of Guernsey wikipedia · Alderney wikipedia · Sark wikipedia [confirmed] · Guernsey Community Foundation grants foundation.gg · Citizens Advice Guernsey citizensadvice.org.gg · St John Guernsey stjohn.gg [confirmed] · Struck: "trees felled after Ciarán exposed others to Goretti" (no source); "Storm Eunice 186 km/h at Albecq" (likely amateur-station error); "over £7m" Foundation giving (actually over £3m). Unreachable: Age Concern Guernsey, Civil Contingencies Authority plans, Guernsey Met Office climate pages, fuel-stock days, flu uptake, permit-worker numbers and languages.
Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory (queried via wp-json/wp/v2/interventions; Toronto cold alerts entry; Germany weatherization entry)
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